Peter, James, John, and Hebrews

Hebrews; James; 1–2 Peter; 1–3 John; Jude

The big idea: These letters were written to Christians who were tired, pressured, and tempted to drift. Hebrews shows that Jesus is better than every priest and sacrifice, and invites us to draw near. James insists that real faith works. Peter gives a living hope in suffering. John writes of God's love and so that believers may know they have eternal life.

Before you meet: Read

Hebrews 4:14–16 | Hebrews 10:11–25 | James 2:14–26 | 1 Peter 1:3–9 | 1 John 4:7–19

Open (5 minutes)

When you are under pressure, what do you tend to drift toward or fall back on?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of _____, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need." *(Hebrews 4:16)*

"Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not _____." *(Hebrews 11:1)*

"So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is _____." *(James 2:17)*

"He has caused us to be born again to a living _____ through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead." *(1 Peter 1:3)*

"If we confess our sins, he is _____ and just to forgive us our sins." *(1 John 1:9)*

"We love because he first _____ us." *(1 John 4:19)*

Discuss

1. Why does it matter that the priests stood daily, but Christ sat down? *Hebrews 10:11–14*

2. Jesus was tempted in every way, yet without sin. How does that change the way you pray? *Hebrews 4:14–16*

3. How would you explain to a friend how Paul and James fit together on faith and works? *James 2:14–26; Romans 3:28*

4. Peter says not to be surprised by suffering. Why do Christians so often feel surprised? *1 Peter 4:12–13; 5:7*

5. John writes so that believers may know they have eternal life. Is that kind of certainty proud or humble? *1 John 5:11–13*

6. Which of these letters do you most need to read this month? Why? *Hebrews 2:3; James 1:22*

Apply this week

Read James and 1 John this week. Pick one command from James and obey it. Bring one specific weakness to Christ in prayer using Hebrews 4:15–16, and write out the reason for the hope that is in you (1 Peter 3:15).

Memory verse

"Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need."

Hebrews 4:16

Pray

Thank Jesus that he is the better High Priest who offered himself once for all and always lives to intercede. Confess your sins and thank him that he is faithful to forgive. Ask for a faith that works by love, and pray for someone who is suffering.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 25

Peter, James, John, and Hebrews

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Hebrews 4:14–16 and James 2:14–17 aloud together. Then read 1 John 4:7–10.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 3, and 5 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Jesus Is Better chart and The General Letters at a Glance in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 26 (Revelation 1:9–18; 4–5; 21:1–22:5).

Main points to land

1. Jesus is better than angels, Moses, the priests, and the sacrifices. His one offering finished the work, and he always lives to intercede (Hebrews 1:1–3; 7:25; 10:11–14).
2. Because our High Priest sympathizes with our weakness, we may draw near to the throne of grace with confidence (Hebrews 4:14–16; 10:19–22).
3. We are justified by faith alone, but saving faith is never alone; it shows itself in works of love (James 2:14–26; Romans 3:28; WCF 11.2).
4. Christians have a living hope that suffering cannot take away (1 Peter 1:3–9; 4:12–13).
5. God is love, and whoever has the Son has life and may know it (1 John 4:7–10; 5:11–13).

Answer key (Observe)

1. grace
2. seen
3. dead
4. hope
5. faithful
6. loved

Questions people will ask

Do Paul and James contradict each other?

No. Paul answers people who think they can earn God's acceptance: we are declared righteous by faith alone (Romans 3:28). James answers people who claim faith but live as if Christ makes no difference: real faith shows itself in works (James 2:18). Paul speaks of the root, James of the fruit.

Do the warnings in Hebrews mean a true Christian can lose salvation?

The warnings are real, and God uses them to keep his people from drifting. Hebrews says that holding firm to the end is the evidence that we have truly come to share in Christ (Hebrews 3:14), and it is confident of better things for true believers (Hebrews 6:9). Christ is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near through him (Hebrews 7:25).

How can anyone be sure they have eternal life?

John wrote so that believers may know (1 John 5:13). Assurance rests first on God's promise in Christ: whoever has the Son has life. It is confirmed by the Spirit's witness and by the fruit of a changed life, like love for God's people (1 John 3:14; Romans 8:16).

Why do Christians still suffer if God loves them?

Peter says suffering tests and refines faith like gold in fire (1 Peter 1:6–7). Christ himself suffered before entering his glory, and those who belong to him share in his sufferings and will share in his glory (1 Peter 4:13). God cares for us in it (1 Peter 5:7).

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, our great High Priest, you offered yourself once for all and you sympathize with our weakness. Keep us from drifting. Give us a faith that works by love, a hope that suffering cannot take away, and the assurance that whoever has the Son has life. We draw near to your throne of grace. Amen.